

Open Source ERPs

Got an enterprise to spare?

Kshitij Sobti

kshitij.sobti@thinkdigit.com

Enterprise

Straight off the bat, the term enterprise resource planning (ERP) seems like a complicated domain, only to be meddled with by people actually running companies. Knowing how different aspects of an ERP program work can be of considerable value to your future employers. If you know how to work some of the open-source ERPs and can customise them, even better.

Also, it is important to understand what such suites have to offer, and how they can be used by *you*, rather than be distracted by the connotations of the label ERP. The millions of people who use Adobe Photoshop for occasionally cropping images are a testament how little the connotations of a program matter.

Function

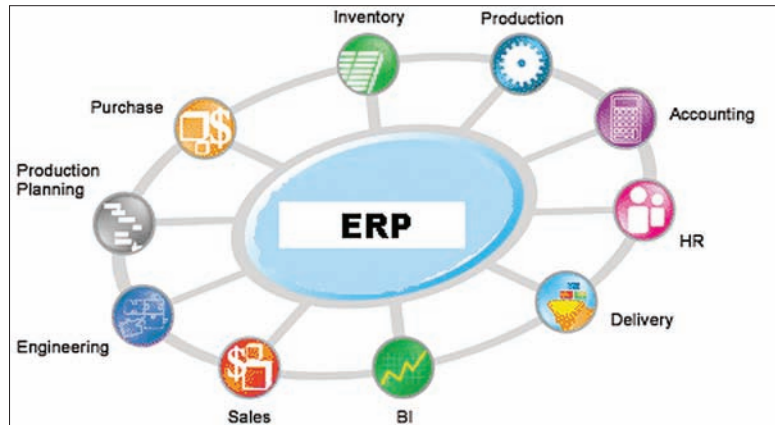
An Enterprise Resource Planning system is a software (and maybe even hardware) solution that facilitates the sharing and processing of an organisation's data. It can significantly help mesh the different resources at the company's disposal, and make managing the different functions of the company better.

Some of the processes that ERPs can handle are:

- Human Resources
- Accounting
- Inventory
- Material Requirements Planning
- Sales Order Entry
- Purchase Order Processing
- Supply Chain Management
- Cash Management
- Warehouse Management
- Bills of Material
- Capacity Requirements Planning

While there are software solutions available which deal with the individual aspects, ERM software is an integration of information and function. Besides integrating the different organisational resources, ERPs can also offer a degree of automation, increasing the efficiency of an organisation.

ERP software stands to change the business process for the better, making it more efficient. Furthermore, by providing



ERP software offer an integration of an enterprises common concerns

better insights into an enterprise's functioning, it can expose further areas for optimisation, in both cost and time. By opting for open source software, there can be further savings in cost.

Resource

For a program to be considered as ERP software, it needs to cater to as many of the enterprise's needs as possible. Bills, costs, inventory, sales, attendance... the list is endless, and data streams in constantly. It is hard to imagine now, just how these tasks were accomplished before computers came on the scene!

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These different streams of data have typical associations to particular resources of an organisation. Depending on the software solution used, an ERP can help an organisation in managing sales, marketing, billing and inventory management. The best thing though is that the environment is integrated, and an overview of all the enterprises resources can easily be obtained.

Integration

Integration is what ERPs are all about.

Software for accomplishing the individual functions are always there, but the reason ERPs are preferred is mainly because they offer an integrated solution. Besides the fact that ERPs offer an integrated solution for an organisation's many domains of functionality, they have little identity of their own.

The main aim of an ERP is to consolidate all the data, and services into one integrated workflow.

Accessibility

Anyone with even a cursory experience with the internet will realise that hyperlinks are perhaps the coolest things around. The way they allow for cross-linking of information is something for which is hard to find a parallel. ERP software in a similar manner allows for the cross connection of data which belongs in completely different streams, and allows them to be compared, compounded and manipulated. It then becomes quite easy to see the relationships between the different organisational resources.

While the more data collected, the better, with increasing amounts of data there is increasing need for better ways to utilise and manipulate this data, and that is something that ERP programs provide. By making it easier to record and utilise this data, they also enable and encourage the collection of more data, and from more diverse aspects of an enterprise's functioning.

An important thing to note is that in today's connected internet-driven world, this data is essentially available in real-time, the benefits of which are obvious. Real-time data means real-time control, where negative